NEW YORK / NOVEMBER 24–27, 2026

New York, *your way.*

The 100th Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade.
Skyline walks, classic food, holiday lights—and a table for four.

Four adults | Thanksgiving: Thursday, November 26 | Options, not a schedule



Research checked October 12, 2026.
All times Eastern. Published prices are not live availability. No bookings have been made.

▼ Open the full guide contents · 32 sections

01 Choose your own New York
02 The parade—and the day before
03 Holiday atmosphere without an entry fee
04 Harbor air & the Manhattan skyline
05 A park above the streets—and a ride above the river
06 Classic New York, with something to do
07 Indoor alternatives—not the whole vacation
08 Skyline experiences without a cruise package
09 Three playful rides, three different settings
10 Games, friendly competition & live jazz
11 Animal experiences at modest admission prices
12 More free experiences tied to a date
13 Historic subway cars & ships you can explore
14 Three more art-and-design bargains
15 Sculpture, a miniature city & Latin American art
16 Chinatown stories, a restored synagogue & photography
17 More history choices under $20
18 Gardens, sculpture & room to wander
19 Playful indoor stops with no admission purchase
20 More free New York places to explore
21 Two November 27 shows with a limited $10 tier
22 Other fun leads—verify before relying on them
23 Bagels, slices & hot dogs
24 Dumplings & New York street-food platters
25 The treats you will talk about afterward
26 Choose the dinner with eyes open
27 Lower-price leads to contact first
28 Explicitly published 2026 dinners
29 What to arrange—and when
30 Reservations for the added options
31 Getting around & keeping the daily total down
32 Final checks & what is deliberately excluded

01

START HERE / OPTIONS, NOT A SCHEDULE

Choose your own New York

Four adults. Four available dates. A collection of events, active experiences, city classics and food—not a prescribed route or daily timetable. Browse by interest, then use each option's availability and booking details.

How to use the collection

Pick what sounds fun: skyline rides, games, animals, holiday displays, architecture, food or art. Nearby pairings are suggestions, never a sequence to follow. Visit lengths are planning estimates.

Each activity shows **possible trip dates, price, location and booking rules**. The HTML lets you filter by date and cost. A date filter includes clearly marked provisional candidates; it does not turn a regular schedule into confirmed holiday opening.

Scope: a broad, researched selection—not a claim to list every event in New York. Some smaller performances and holiday operations have not released final details. Later announcements belong in the watchlist, not the confirmed collection.

Price and availability labels

Free: no ordinary admission charge for the option described. **Under $20:** published adult admission or the specific activity described is below $20—not $20 or less. Transport, meals and optional extras are separate.

Conditional: limited discount tickets, unconfirmed seasonal opening, an unverified checkout total or a self-set spending cap. These are separated from firm price options. For near-limit tickets, check mandatory fees before paying.

Published 2026 identifies this year/date explicitly. **Regular schedule** is a standing policy with holiday exceptions possible. All times are Eastern. Research checked October 12, 2026. No tickets or tables have been booked.

Available dates: Tuesday, November 24; Wednesday, November 25; Thanksgiving Thursday, November 26; Friday, November 27, 2026. The event is the 100th Macy's parade—not the 100th anniversary of its 1924 start. Hotel name and departure times have not been provided.

02 EVENTS / THE MAIN EVENT

The parade—and the day before

Thursday, November 26, 2026 · Public sidewalk viewing: $0 for four · No public grandstand tickets are sold by Macy's.

2026 DATE CONFIRMED

100th Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade

> **Available:** Thu Nov 26 · 2026 date confirmed

What you will see: enormous character balloons, floats, marching bands and performers moving through Manhattan. Macy's announces an 8:30 am television start; that is **not** the time the parade reaches every hotel or viewing block.

Planning route: Central Park West → Columbus Circle → Central Park South → Sixth Avenue → Herald Square. Common public-viewing stretches are the west side of Central Park West around 75th–61st Streets and Sixth Avenue north of the 38th Street broadcast area. These are planning references, not a substitute for the final 2026 Macy's/NYPD access map. Macy's current FAQ says designated viewing details are still forthcoming.

Street-viewing strategy: plan to be out around 5:30–6 am if a front position matters; even that is not a guarantee for the 100th parade. Stay on the same side of the route as the hotel where possible. Expect standing, security, restricted crossings and limited restroom access. Do not count on leaving a spot and returning.

Avoid: assuming Herald Square grandstands are public, buying purported general-public grandstand tickets, or assuming the televised Broadway stage performances are visible from an ordinary sidewalk position. Leave large bags at the hotel and recheck the official prohibited-item rules before packing for the morning.

Macy's: public viewing & balloon updates ↗ | Macy's: 100th parade announcement ↗ | Rockefeller Center: parade viewing reference ↗

PUBLIC ACCESS STILL PENDING

Wednesday balloon inflation

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 · public access/times pending

Macy's confirms balloon preparation on **Wednesday, November 25 on the Upper West Side**. Public viewing hours, entry point and access rules are **not yet announced**. Traditionally, viewers walk past balloons around the American Museum of Natural History as crews prepare them at street level.

Cost: traditionally free; no verified 2026 ticket or registration process yet. Hold roughly 2–3 hours including possible queues, but do not attach a firm time to it now. Check the official FAQ before heading over. If public access returns, this is one of the best parade-related additions; it is not necessarily quieter than parade day.

Macy's: public viewing & balloon updates ↗

Hotel on the route ≠ parade-view room. Ask whether all four guests have guaranteed room/lounge/terrace viewing, any additional fee, the required arrival time, and the approved entrance during street closures. Get the answer in writing.

EVENTS / MARKETS & CITY LIGHTS

03 Holiday atmosphere without an entry fee

These are experiences to enjoy, not instructions to shop. The Grand Central market dates are published for 2026; holiday operating details still deserve a final check.

$0 TO BROWSE

Bryant Park Winter Village

40th–42nd Streets, between Fifth & Sixth Avenues

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · holiday hours require confirmation

An outdoor holiday market surrounds an ice rink: browse small stalls, watch skaters and take evening photos. Allow **45–90 minutes**. The shops announce an October 28, 2026 opening; older detailed shop-hour text remains on the site, so recheck Thanksgiving hours. **No reservation to browse.**

Optional skating: entry is free with your own skates and a reserved slot. Posted rentals are **$18.72–$64.48 each before tax**, including the stated administrative fee—roughly **$82–$281 for four with a tax allowance**, before storage. The page mixes new-season and older wording; use the exact-date checkout total. Watching is the better no-spend choice. Bumper cars are not a November option under the current notice.

Bryant Park: holiday shops ↗ | Bryant Park: prices, rules & reservations ↗

2026 PUBLISHED

Grand Central Holiday Fair

Vanderbilt Hall, 89 East 42nd Street

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24, Wed Nov 25, Fri Nov 27 · closed Thanksgiving

A warm indoor artisan market inside the landmark terminal: jewelry, gifts, artwork and browsing, rather than a show. Runs **November 9–December 24, 2026; closed Thanksgiving**. Choose Tuesday, Wednesday or Friday. Allow **30–45 minutes** and combine it with the station's Whispering Gallery. **$0 for four; no browsing reservation.** Check the organizer's current daily hours.

Grand Central: 2026 Holiday Fair ↗

TUESDAY ONLY

Grand Central Thanksgiving Market

Biltmore Room, near Track 42

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24 · 1–6 pm · published 2026 listing

A small seasonal food market with terminal vendors—not a festival requiring half a day. The official listing says **Tuesday, November 24, 2026, 1–6 pm**. Allow **20–40 minutes** if already in the terminal. No admission ticket is advertised; purchases cost extra and samples are not guaranteed.

Grand Central: current event calendar ↗

FREE NIGHTLY PROGRAM

Midnight Moment in Times Square

Digital displays around 41st–49th Streets

> **Available:** Nightly Nov 24–27 · 11:57 pm–midnight

At **11:57 pm–midnight**, many billboards switch to a synchronized artwork. It is a three-minute visual experience, not a concert or fireworks show. **$0; no booking.** The program lists a November 2026 work by Julien Creuzet. Arrive a little early, look up, and decide whether a late night appeals to the group.

Times Square: Midnight Moment ↗

ATTRACTIONS / THE BEST BIG-CITY VIEWS

04 Harbor air & the Manhattan skyline

Independent harbor and waterfront choices, with no assigned day or route. Weather and the amount of walking the group wants should guide the selection.

$0 FOR ALL FOUR

Staten Island Ferry

Whitehall Terminal, 4 South Street, Manhattan

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · Thanksgiving uses holiday service

A working commuter ferry—not a narrated tour—crosses New York Harbor. You see Lower Manhattan, shipping traffic and the Statue of Liberty **from a distance**. It does not stop at Liberty or Ellis Island.

Plan: approximately 25 minutes each way; allow **75–100 minutes** with boarding and the return connection. Everyone must get off at Staten Island and reboard for the return. Aim for a daylight ride; enclosed areas provide a break from wind. **No ticket or reservation.**

Thanksgiving uses the weekend schedule, normally half-hourly. Check same-day service for weather changes. Ignore street sellers offering a ticket for this free ferry. Pair with the nearby free Smithsonian museum only if the group genuinely wants an indoor stop.

NYC DOT: free ferry schedule ↗ | NYC DOT: ferry traveler information ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 · NO BOOKING

Walk the Brooklyn Bridge

Pedestrian promenade between Lower Manhattan and Brooklyn

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · ordinary public access, weather permitting

Walk through the bridge's stone towers and web of suspension cables, with city and river views in both directions. It is an experience in itself, not just a photo stop. Allow **45–60 minutes one way** at a relaxed photo pace; add time to reach the waterfront.

From Manhattan, use the pedestrian entrance near City Hall/Park Row. From Brooklyn, the Tillary Street/Boerum Place entrance offers the main ramp approach; consult the access link for alternatives. Walking from Brooklyn toward Manhattan puts the skyline ahead; walking the other way finishes near DUMBO after an additional walk.

Wear wind-blocking layers and comfortable shoes. Take the subway back rather than committing to a second crossing. If it is wet, icy or unpleasantly windy, shorten the plan to a waterfront visit or indoor alternative.

NYC DOT: Brooklyn Bridge ↗ | Brooklyn Bridge Park: pedestrian access ↗ | Map & directions ↗

FREE WATERFRONT · CAROUSEL $4 EACH

DUMBO waterfront + Jane's Carousel

Brooklyn Bridge Park, near Dock & Water Streets

> **Available:** Waterfront: Nov 24–27; carousel: Wed/Fri; Thu holiday hours unconfirmed

DUMBO is the waterfront neighborhood between the Brooklyn and Manhattan Bridges. Explore the public paths around Empire Fulton Ferry for skyline photographs; the familiar Washington Street view frames the Manhattan Bridge. Stay out of the roadway for photos. Allow **45–90 minutes** beyond the bridge crossing.

Jane's Carousel is a restored historic merry-go-round inside a glass pavilion by the river. Adults can ride too. Its official fall schedule lists **Wednesday–Sunday, 11 am–5:50 pm; $4 per rider**—not the $3 in older listings. No advance reservation for a normal ride. Confirm Thanksgiving exceptions before relying on Thursday. Viewing the waterfront costs nothing.

Brooklyn Bridge Park: waterfront ↗ | Jane's Carousel: current hours & tickets ↗ | Map & directions ↗

ATTRACTIONS / ACTIVE & MEMORABLE

05 A park above the streets—and a ride above the river

Three independent choices: an elevated park, a sculpted river park and an aerial tram. Each can be enjoyed on its own; there is no assigned sightseeing day.

$0 · WALK IN

The High Line

Manhattan's West Side, from Gansevoort Street toward 34th Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · regular November hours 7 am–10 pm

A former elevated freight-rail line is now a pedestrian park. Walk above street level past planted beds, changing public art and unusual close-up views of buildings. Old tracks and lookout areas make it more interesting than a standard sidewalk walk.

Allow 45–75 minutes for a selected stretch, not necessarily the entire park. A useful route is the 30th Street area south toward Gansevoort Street. Published November hours are **7 am–10 pm**. No ordinary entry ticket. Check the official elevator-status link if anyone needs step-free access. Bicycles and recreational scooters are not allowed on the park.

Little Island and the Whitney are nearby options, not required next stops.

High Line: hours, entrances & elevator status ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 · NO ORDINARY PARK TICKET

Little Island

Pier 55, Hudson River Park, near West 13th Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · regular November hours 6 am–9 pm

An unusually shaped public park rises from the Hudson on tulip-like concrete supports. Follow winding paths up to overlooks for river and skyline views. It is a short exploratory walk with good photo angles—not an amusement park.

Allow 30–45 minutes. Published November hours are **6 am–9 pm**, weather permitting. Normal park entry is free; performances can require separate paid tickets, and no November show is promised here. Reach it from the southern end of the High Line with a street-level walk toward the river. Visit in daylight when footing and views are easier.

Little Island: hours & visiting rules ↗ | Map & directions ↗

UP TO $24 RETURN FOR FOUR

Roosevelt Island Tram

East 60th Street & Second Avenue, Manhattan

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · regular service; check maintenance

Ride in an aerial cabin above traffic and the East River alongside the Queensboro Bridge. The crossing is only a few minutes, but the changing skyline view makes it feel like an attraction. On the island, take a short waterfront walk before returning.

Allow 45–75 minutes including waits and a stroll. RIOC accepts the standard MTA fare: currently **$3 each way per person**, or $12 for four one-way/$24 for a return before eligible transfer benefits. Pay with OMNY/contactless; no advance sightseeing reservation. Do not assume a round trip on the tram is one fare.

Published hours cover the trip: Sun–Thu 6 am–2 am; Fri–Sat 6 am–3:30 am. Prefer an off-peak daylight ride and check for maintenance. This is separate from the free Staten Island Ferry.

RIOC: Roosevelt Island Tram ↗ | MTA: current subway & bus fares ↗ | Map & directions ↗

06 ATTRACTIONS / WALK · TRY · PHOTOGRAPH

Classic New York, with something to do

These all have $0 admission for ordinary public sightseeing. They work best as short experiences rather than a checklist of buildings.

60–90 MINUTES · DAYLIGHT

Central Park's movie-scene walk

The Mall → Bethesda Terrace → Bow Bridge

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · daylight recommended; parade closures Thu

Walk the broad tree-lined promenade, explore the tiled arcade at Bethesda Terrace, then find the curving Bow Bridge over the Lake. Make it a photo challenge: each person chooses one view for a shared album. No reservation for a self-guided visit.

Current detail missed in the earlier guide: the Conservancy flags fountain restoration and says Bethesda Fountain will be off; the terrace remains accessible. Do not promise a running fountain. Recheck works and do not rely on seasonal park restrooms being open. Nearby Upper West Side food stops are optional.

Central Park: Bethesda Terrace & current works ↗ | Central Park: Bow Bridge ↗ | Map & directions ↗

30–45 MINUTES · INDOORS

Grand Central + the Whispering Gallery

89 East 42nd Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · terminal access; individual shops vary

Look up at the celestial ceiling and across the huge main concourse. Then try the Whispering Gallery outside the Oyster Bar: two people stand at diagonally opposite corners of the arched space and speak toward the wall. The sound carries surprisingly well. Keep voices low and do not block commuters.

No reservation. Add either holiday market while it is open. The terminal and individual shops have different hours; a closed Holiday Fair does not mean the whole station is closed.

MTA: Grand Central secrets & Whispering Gallery ↗ | Grand Central: 2026 Holiday Fair ↗ | Map & directions ↗

45–60 MINUTES · EXTERIORS

Rockefeller Center + Fifth Avenue window walk

Around 49th–50th Streets and Fifth/Sixth Avenues

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · public plaza; tree not yet lit

Watch skaters from the public plaza, photograph the Art Deco setting, and browse nearby store windows. There is no need to buy a skating or observation-deck ticket. Store entry may have a queue.

The tree will not yet be lit: official 2026 arrival is November 7 and lighting is **December 2**, after this trip. Holiday-window unveilings and any Saks light show are separate announcements; enjoy what is installed without promising a show. No normal public-plaza reservation.

Rockefeller Center: 2026 tree dates ↗ | Map & directions ↗

20–40 MINUTES · ANY EVENING

Times Square after dark

Broadway/Seventh Avenue in the 40s

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · ordinary public access

See the enormous screens and theater marquees, people-watch, and take a group photo. A short visit is usually enough; staying until midnight is optional. No ticket or reservation for public sightseeing.

For a small-group activity, each person picks their favorite marquee or billboard, then choose a shared dessert nearby. Costumed-character photos and street-performer interactions can come with tip requests; ordinary street views do not require payment.

Times Square: Midnight Moment ↗ | Map & directions ↗

07 ATTRACTIONS / CHOOSE ONE THAT FITS

Indoor alternatives—not the whole vacation

These preserve the useful options from the original PDF. Pick by interest or weather rather than spending the trip hopping between museums. Regular schedules require a final holiday check.

BEST EVENING ART OPTION

Whitney Museum of American Art

99 Gansevoort Street

> **Available:** Fri Nov 27 · free 5–10 pm; tickets required

Modern American paintings, sculpture, photography and installations, plus city views from terraces when accessible. Allow **90–120 minutes**. Friday's **5–10 pm** program is free for everyone; timed tickets are required. Check for November 27 starting **October 23**, based on the up-to-five-week window—not a verified release hour. Visitors aged 25 or under can obtain free admission on other open days with the required ticket and ID; this guide does not assume that discount for all four adults.

Whitney: Free Friday Nights ↗ | Reserve Whitney Free Friday tickets ↗ | Whitney: free admission for ages 25 & under ↗

ORNATE INTERIORS

Morgan Library & Museum

225 Madison Avenue

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24: historic rooms 3–5 pm; Fri Nov 27: 5–8 pm ticketed

A richly decorated historic private library and galleries for art, books and manuscripts. **Tuesday 3–5 pm:** historic rooms only, free without a reservation. **Friday 5–8 pm:** full free-evening admission with a reservation, released one week ahead—target **November 20**. Allow 45–90 minutes. Reserve only if the available evening hours suit the travelers. Closed Thanksgiving under its regular holiday policy.

Morgan: admission & historic rooms ↗ | Morgan: Free Friday reservations ↗

DOWNTOWN · $0

National Museum of the American Indian

One Bowling Green

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · regular hours 10 am–5 pm

A Smithsonian museum of Indigenous cultures, art and history in a grand former Custom House. Allow 45–90 minutes; free and no ticket. Published hours are **10 am–5 pm daily except December 25**, making it a possible Thanksgiving indoor stop. Check operational notices before travel. Convenient beside the free ferry, not beside the parade.

Smithsonian: New York museum visit ↗

SMALLER FREE CHOICES

Museum at FIT / American Folk Art Museum

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 & Fri Nov 27; Thursday holiday access not assumed

FIT, 227 W. 27th: changing displays of fashion, garments and design; 45–60 minutes. Wednesday/Friday noon–8 pm, free ordinary admission; closed Tuesday and Thanksgiving. **Folk Art, 2 Lincoln Square:** distinctive paintings, carvings and handmade works by folk/self-taught artists; 30–60 minutes. Regular Wed–Sun 11:30 am–6 pm; free walk-in. Verify holiday exceptions; do not assume Thursday opening.

Museum at FIT: hours & admission ↗ | American Folk Art Museum: visiting ↗

OPTIONAL, NOT PRIORITIES

Two short Grand Central / Bryant Park add-ons

> **Available:** Tue/Wed/Fri candidates · confirm individual exhibition hours

NYPL Treasures: rare books and historical objects in the Fifth Avenue/42nd Street library; allow 30–45 minutes, $0, check its free-ticket process and holiday hours. **Transit Museum's Grand Central Gallery:** a small free changing exhibition in the Shuttle Passage; allow 15–30 minutes. Regular weekdays 10 am–7:30 pm; closed Thanksgiving. The paid Brooklyn Transit Museum is a different location. A 2026 holiday model-train show is not treated as a confirmed stop here.

NYPL: Treasures exhibition & entry ↗ | Transit Museum: free Grand Central gallery ↗

08 ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / FERRIES & AN ARCHITECTURAL CLIMB

Skyline experiences without a cruise package

Independent choices with distinctive views. These are not substitutes for a visit to Liberty Island, and none requires an attraction pass.

$4.50 ONE WAY · $9 RETURN

NYC Ferry · East River skyline ride

NYC Ferry Pier 11 Wall Street, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · regular service; use the exact-date holiday timetable

Ride a commuter boat past waterfront neighborhoods and bridge spans. Choose a route and landing that appeal—Wall Street/Pier 11 to DUMBO is a short hop; a longer East River trip gives more time on the water. This is not a narrated cruise.

Price: $4.50 per one-way ticket; four adults $18 one way or $36 for two separately paid journeys. A return ride is not a free transfer. Subway/OMNY fares do not cover NYC Ferry.

Booking: buy through the NYC Ferry app or landing machine; ordinary tickets do not reserve a seat. Allow 30–90 minutes depending on the chosen route and waits. Check winter service and use indoor seating in cold weather.

NYC Ferry: fares, app & ticket rules ↗ | NYC Ferry: live routes & schedules ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$5 ROUND-TRIP FERRY · $20 FOR FOUR

Governors Island · harbor views and open space

Battery Maritime Building, 10 South Street, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · year-round daily operation; recheck holiday ferry service

A short ferry crossing leads to paths, former military buildings and elevated viewpoints facing the harbor and Lower Manhattan. Explore on foot; paid bike hire, food and the spa are separate, optional purchases. Allow 2–3 hours including travel.

Price: the Trust-operated ferry from Manhattan is $5 round trip; ordinary island access is free. The weekend-before-11-am free offer does not apply to these Tuesday–Friday dates. Published fall island hours are 7 am–6 pm.

Booking: reserve the outbound ferry online; the return is included. Do not rely on the seasonal Trust-operated Brooklyn ferries, which finish before this trip. NYC Ferry is a different operator with different tickets. Wind, food-vendor closures and ferry frequency can affect the experience.

Governors Island: official ferry tickets ↗ | Governors Island: hours & visitor alerts ↗ | Map & directions ↗

CONDITIONAL: FROM $10 + $2 FEE + TAX

Vessel · climb the honeycomb-like stair structure

Vessel, 20 Hudson Yards, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · exact-date price and entry slot must be checked

Explore interconnected stairs and landings for geometric photographs and views of Hudson Yards. This is an architectural climb, not an observation deck at skyscraper height. Allow 30–60 minutes; check step-free access and current restrictions before booking.

The official FAQ advertises tickets **from $10, plus a $2 per-ticket processing fee and tax**. November holiday inventory at that starting price was not verified. Include it only if the final checkout is below $20 per person; do not buy a higher-priced Edge bundle by mistake.

Reserve a dated/timed entry through the official site. The Thursday free offer is restricted to NYC residents and is not assumed for this party. Looking at Vessel from the public plaza is free.

Vessel: tickets & visit details ↗ | Vessel: prices, processing fee & access rules ↗ | Map & directions ↗

09 ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / CAROUSELS ARE NOT JUST FOR CHILDREN

Three playful rides, three different settings

Short optional experiences rather than full outings. Jane's Carousel in DUMBO is also retained in the waterfront section at $4 per rider.

$6 EACH · $24 FOR FOUR

SeaGlass Carousel · luminous fish at The Battery

SeaGlass Carousel, The Battery, New York

> **Available:** Fri Nov 27: 11 am–8 pm; Thu listed 11 am–7 pm, holiday opening unconfirmed

Sit inside a glowing fish as the ride turns through an aquatic light-and-music setting. It is an unusual short ride and a fun photograph opportunity near the free Staten Island Ferry. Allow 15–30 minutes including any queue.

Tickets: $6 each, purchased on site; no standard advance reservation. The operator's 2026 calendar explicitly lists Friday hours. Its November wording lists Sunday and Thursday but does not clearly cover Tuesday/Wednesday, so those dates are not promised. Confirm Thanksgiving and same-day weather/maintenance updates.

SeaGlass Carousel: tickets & operating calendar ↗ | SeaGlass: official 2026 operating calendar ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$6 EACH IN NOVEMBER · $24 FOR FOUR

Le Carrousel · a quick Bryant Park extra

Le Carrousel, Bryant Park, 40th Street, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24, 25, 27: 11 am–8 pm; Thanksgiving: noon–8 pm, weather permitting

A small French-style carousel with painted animals and cabaret music beside the park's holiday activity. It is a few-minute playful break, not an amusement-park attraction. Allow 10–20 minutes.

Seasonal price matters: the operator lists $6 per ride from November 3 through January 4, not the $5 off-season price. Buy on site; no ordinary ride reservation. Browsing the surrounding holiday market remains free.

Bryant Park: Le Carrousel prices & holiday hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$4 EACH · $16 FOR FOUR

Central Park Carousel · the classic wooden-horse ride

Central Park Carousel, Mid-Park at 65th Street, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · regular daily 10 am–dusk, weather permitting; parade access can differ

Ride a historic carousel with carved horses and mechanical-organ music in the southern part of Central Park. Adults can ride; it makes a short, old-fashioned New York memory without a large ticket purchase.

Tickets: $4 each through the operator or at the carousel. Allow 15–25 minutes and check same-day operation. A ticket is not a promise of unrestricted park access during Thursday's parade closures.

Central Park Carousel: official tickets ↗ | Central Park Conservancy: carousel visiting ↗ | Map & directions ↗

10

ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / INDOOR SOCIAL OPTIONS

Games, friendly competition & live jazz

These are alternatives to another sightseeing building. Keep activity charges separate from drinks and food, and check holiday opening before traveling.

$15 WALK-IN GAMEPLAY · $60 FOR FOUR

Hex&Co. · choose a board game together

Hex and Company, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24, 25, 27: regular weekday candidates; Thu Thanksgiving opening unconfirmed

Choose from a large board-game library and ask staff for something that works for four people. A cooperative mystery, party game or strategy game gives everyone something to do together. Allow 1½–3 hours.

Price: $15 per person for walk-in gameplay, with no normal weekday time limit. Food and drinks are extra. Advance seating starts at $17 per person and carries a three-hour limit; verify fees and holiday rules before choosing that tier.

Booking: walk-ins are the lower posted price, subject to seating. Use the official locations page to choose the correct branch, then its reservation gateway if desired. Discounted student/child rates are not assumed in the four-adult total.

Hex&Co.: gameplay prices & reservations ↗ | Hex&Co.: current locations ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$8–9 PER PLAYER/HOUR BEFORE 6 PM

Cellar Dog · pool, ping-pong, shuffleboard or jazz

Cellar Dog, 75 Christopher Street, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24, 25, 27: regular candidates from 4 pm; Thu holiday hours/lineup unconfirmed

A West Village basement with games and live jazz. Play a timed round of pool, ping-pong or shuffleboard, or choose a small table game. Allow about an hour for games; a music visit can be longer.

Posted rates: before 6 pm, games are $8 per player/hour Tue–Thu or $9 Fri, billed by the minute; four players are $32 or $36 for one hour. Board games are $2 per person. After 6 pm, add a $5 cover Tue–Thu or $10 Fri. Jazz normally starts at 7 pm; drinks and any minimum spend must be checked separately.

Walk-in, first-come seating. After 6 pm the venue is 21+ unless an underage guest is accompanied by their **parent**; another adult does not automatically qualify. Confirm the party's eligibility and Thanksgiving opening directly. A Friday hour of games plus cover is $19 before any extras, so the before-6-pm option is safer for this limit.

Cellar Dog NYC: cover, games & age rules ↗ | Cellar Dog NYC: music & location ↗ | Map & directions ↗

11

ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / TWO SMALL ZOOS + A FREE WEDNESDAY

Animal experiences at modest admission prices

Zoo admission covers an ordinary daytime visit, not a separately ticketed lights festival. Individual animals and feedings are never guaranteed.

$10.95 EACH · $43.80 FOR FOUR

Prospect Park Zoo · a compact Brooklyn zoo

Prospect Park Zoo, 450 Flatbush Avenue, Brooklyn

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · published winter daily hours 10 am–4:30 pm; last entry 3:30 pm

Walk a manageable zoo with animal habitats, indoor areas and a central sea-lion setting. It is a shorter animal outing than the Bronx Zoo and can be combined with an optional walk in Prospect Park. Allow 1½–2 hours.

Booking: all nonmember visitors need date-specific tickets. Purchase through the official site and check exact-date availability and any checkout additions. Published adult admission is $10.95. Recheck holiday operational notices and the day's animal schedule.

Prospect Park Zoo: date-specific tickets & winter hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$10.95 EACH · $43.80 FOR FOUR

Queens Zoo · wildlife in Flushing Meadows

Queens Zoo, 53-51 111th Street, Queens

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · published winter daily hours 10 am–4:30 pm; check last entry

An outdoor zoo focused on animals of the Americas, with paths through habitats and an aviary. Allow 1½–2 hours. The Unisphere and Queens Museum are separate nearby choices, not required additions.

Booking: reserve a date-specific $10.95 adult ticket through the official site. Check the final checkout, winter last-entry time and holiday notices. Bring warm layers; this is not an entirely indoor activity.

Queens Zoo: date-specific tickets & winter hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 WITH THE CORRECT RESERVED TICKET

Bronx Zoo · free limited admission on Wednesday

Bronx Zoo, 2300 Southern Boulevard, Bronx

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 only for this offer · 10 am–4:30 pm; exhibits generally close 4 pm

Explore the zoo grounds and the animal exhibits included in limited admission. This is a large park; allow 2½–4 hours there, plus substantial travel from Midtown. Free does not mean every attraction is included.

Required reservation: the Wednesday ticket store opens **Monday, November 23 at 5 pm Eastern**. Select the free **Wednesday LIMITED Admission** ticket. Capacity is limited; do not arrive without a reservation.

Star Attractions such as JungleWorld and Congo Gorilla Forest cost extra under limited admission; the published add-on is $7 per attraction. This is not a free Holiday Lights ticket. The Bronx Zoo is closed on Thanksgiving under its published winter policy.

Bronx Zoo: free Wednesday reservations ↗ | Bronx Zoo: free-admission terms ↗ | Bronx Zoo: winter hours & holiday closures ↗ | Map & directions ↗

12

EVENTS & FREE WINDOWS / GINGERBREAD · AQUARIUM · WATERFRONT WALK

More free experiences tied to a date

These have a particular free window or event date. Their timing is information for making your own choices—not a suggested sequence.

$0 ON WEDNESDAY

Gingerbread NYC · vote for an edible city

Museum of the City of New York, 1220 Fifth Avenue, New York

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 · free Wednesday admission; regular Wednesday hours 10 am–9 pm

See miniature New York landmarks made from gingerbread, icing and candy in *The Great Borough Bake-Off 2026*. Bakers interpret “Iconic New York,” and visitors can vote for a People’s Choice winner. The exhibition opens November 6, 2026. Allow 45–90 minutes, with other museum galleries included.

Booking: free Wednesday admission is obtained at the ticket counter, not by purchasing the normal $23 adult ticket online. No general advance reservation is advertised for this free offer. The museum closes Thanksgiving; its ordinary paid ticket is over the requested limit.

Gingerbread NYC: 2026 exhibition ↗ | Museum of the City of New York: free Wednesdays ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 WITH RESERVED WEDNESDAY TICKETS

New York Aquarium · free Wednesday afternoon

New York Aquarium, 602 Surf Avenue, Brooklyn

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 · free after 3 pm; winter last entry 3:30 pm, closes 4:30 pm

See marine habitats and the aquarium's underwater displays near the Coney Island boardwalk. This is an engaging animal option, but the free winter window is short and the trip from Midtown is long. Allow up to 90 minutes inside, plus travel.

Required booking: reserve at **3 pm Eastern on Monday, November 23** for Wednesday, November 25. Maximum four tickets per order. Do not go without a reserved ticket, and use the precise entry time printed on it.

The 4-D theater is not included in free Wednesday admission. Do not assume the outdoor amusement rides are operating in late November. Check closures and animal-program timing rather than promising a show.

New York Aquarium: Wednesday ticket reservations ↗ | New York Aquarium: free-admission rules ↗ | New York Aquarium: winter hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 · WALKERS WELCOME

NYRR Open Run · walk or jog beside the skyline

Brooklyn Bridge Park Pier 6, south side of Fornino, Brooklyn

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24 · check in 6:45 pm; regular start 7 pm

Join a community-led run or walk of roughly three miles with Lower Manhattan and river views. You do not need to race; walking and doing a comfortable distance are welcome. Allow about an hour and dress for a dark, potentially windy waterfront.

NYC Parks has a November 24 listing; NYRR gives the 7 pm start and asks for check-in 15 minutes earlier. **Register through NYRR's official page** to speed check-in; review any event-day cancellation notice. This is a local social activity, not a guided history tour.

NYRR: Brooklyn Bridge Park Open Run registration ↗ | NYC Parks: November 24 Open Run listing ↗ | Map & directions ↗

13

ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / MORE THAN DISPLAY CASES

Historic subway cars & ships you can explore

Two distinctly New York experiences. These are paid museums, but the draw is entering the historic vehicles and spaces.

$15 EACH · $60 FOR FOUR

New York Transit Museum · step inside old subway cars

New York Transit Museum, 99 Schermerhorn Street, Brooklyn

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 & Fri Nov 27 · 10 am–4 pm; closed Tue and Thanksgiving

Visit a decommissioned subway station filled with historic transit vehicles and exhibits. Walk through vintage subway cars, compare their seats and advertisements, and see how the city's transport changed. Allow 1½–2 hours.

Reserve a timed ticket: adult admission is $15; tickets become available three weeks in advance—**November 4 for Nov 25**, and **November 6 for Nov 27**. Limited walk-in tickets may remain, but are not guaranteed. This is separate from the free Grand Central gallery.

Transit Museum: Brooklyn tickets, hours & release window ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$18 ADULT ADMISSION · $72 FOR FOUR

South Street Seaport Museum · ships and maritime New York

South Street Seaport Museum, 12 Fulton Street and Pier 16, New York

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25: reserved 1–3 or 3–5 pm; Fri Nov 27: regular 11 am–5 pm

General admission includes maritime exhibitions and access to the tall ship *Wavertree* and lightship *Ambrose*, subject to weather and tour operations. See working and living spaces aboard historic vessels—not just boats from shore. Allow about two hours; the ships do not sail during an ordinary museum visit.

November rules: Wednesday requires preregistration, with booking closing three days before the visit. For Nov 25, book before the Nov 22 cutoff. Friday permits walk-ins or advance tickets; last regular entry is 4:30 pm. Verify the full online price stays under $20 if booking digitally; $18 is the published adult admission, not a verified checkout quote.

Thursday Thanksgiving access is not confirmed and is not offered here. At nearby Bowne & Co., ordinary shop browsing and seeing historic printing equipment is free during opening hours; hands-on workshops are separate.

Seaport Museum: $18 admission & November booking rules ↗ | Map & directions ↗

14

ATTRACTIONS & FREE WINDOWS / SHORT VISITS OR A RAINY-DAY CHOICE

Three more art-and-design bargains

These free or pay-what-you-wish windows apply to visitors without requiring NYC residency.

WEDNESDAY PAY-WHAT-YOU-WISH

The Frick Collection · art inside a grand mansion

The Frick Collection, 1 East 70th Street, New York

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 · 1:30–5:30 pm pay-what-you-wish window

Explore European paintings, sculpture and decorative art in a historic Fifth Avenue mansion, including its enclosed Garden Court. Allow 60–90 minutes; this is a quiet art-and-interiors experience rather than an interactive attraction.

Book online: the pay-what-you-wish reservation minimum is **$5 per ticket**, or $20 for four at that contribution. Smaller contributions are possible at the door on Wednesday, but admission is not guaranteed. Select the correct Wednesday afternoon tier, not regular admission. Closed Thanksgiving.

Frick: Wednesday pay-what-you-wish reservations ↗ | Frick: hours, tickets & visitor policies ↗ | Map & directions ↗

PAY WHAT YOU WISH · 5–6 PM

Cooper Hewitt · design in the Carnegie mansion

Cooper Hewitt Smithsonian Design Museum, 2 East 91st Street, New York

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24, Wed Nov 25, Fri Nov 27 · 5–6 pm; closed Thanksgiving

Explore design exhibitions inside Andrew Carnegie's former mansion. The appeal is how everyday objects, materials and visual ideas are designed; displays depend on the exhibitions open during the visit. Allow the one-hour discounted window.

Use the official ticket/visitor page for the 5–6 pm pay-what-you-wish entry. The current $10 daytime rate is a temporary reduction during gallery changeover, so it is **not promised for late November**. Check which galleries and interactives are actually available; do not assume every floor is open.

Cooper Hewitt: pay-what-you-wish hours & tickets ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 EVERY FRIDAY

Poster House · bold images, advertising and design

Poster House, 119 West 23rd Street, New York

> **Available:** Fri Nov 27 · regular free Friday hours 10 am–9 pm; final entry 8:30 pm

A compact museum devoted to posters as art, persuasion and popular culture. Compare striking graphics and historical advertising rather than working through a vast art collection. Allow 45–75 minutes.

Walk in: general admission is free every Friday, with no advance general-ticket reservation under current policy. Closed Tuesday, Wednesday and Thanksgiving, so Friday is the only regular opening in the trip window. Recheck holiday notices before leaving the hotel.

Poster House: free Friday hours ↗ | Poster House: walk-in admission ↗ | Map & directions ↗

15

ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / ADMISSION UNDER $20

Sculpture, a miniature city & Latin American art

Interest-led alternatives with very different collections. These are not required stops; choose only what appeals.

$16 EACH · $64 FOR FOUR

Noguchi Museum · sculpture and glowing paper lights

The Noguchi Museum, 9-01 33rd Road, Queens

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 & Fri Nov 27 · regular 11 am–6 pm; Thanksgiving not assumed

Explore Isamu Noguchi's sculpture in indoor galleries and a garden. *No Ordinary Light: Akari at 75*, opening November 4, 2026, places his celebrated light sculptures alongside work in other materials. Allow 60–90 minutes.

Walk in: the museum currently sells $16 adult admission on arrival and is not taking advance reservations. The temporary half-price installation period ends November 1, before this trip. The free first-Friday offer does not apply to November 27. Recheck holiday closures and last entry, currently 5:30 pm.

Noguchi Museum: $16 admission & hours ↗ | Noguchi: No Ordinary Light, Akari at 75 ↗ | Map & directions ↗

PAY WHAT YOU WISH · $8 ADULT SUGGESTION

Queens Museum · New York in miniature

Queens Museum, Flushing Meadows Corona Park, Queens

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 & Fri Nov 27 · noon–5 pm; last gallery entry 4:30 pm

Look over the Panorama of the City of New York, an expansive scale model that makes the boroughs, bridges and skyline easier to understand. Changing exhibitions provide other reasons to explore. Allow 60–90 minutes; the Unisphere is an optional free outdoor photo stop nearby.

Reserve a timed ticket through the museum's visitor page. Admission is pay what you wish; $8 is the suggested adult contribution, not a compulsory fixed fee. Four people contributing $8 each would pay $32. Tuesday is closed; Thanksgiving opening is not confirmed here.

Queens Museum: pay-what-you-wish tickets ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$9 ADULT SUGGESTED ADMISSION

El Museo del Barrio · Latin American and Caribbean art

El Museo del Barrio, 1230 Fifth Avenue, New York

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 & Fri Nov 27 · regular 11 am–6 pm; closed Thanksgiving

A focused museum of Latin American, Caribbean and Latinx art, with changing exhibitions rather than a huge encyclopedic collection. Allow 45–90 minutes. Read the current exhibition description before choosing it.

Admission: the museum publishes a $9 suggested adult price; four contributions of that amount are $36. Use the official visitor page for ticket details. Its published 2-for-1 arrangement also permits same-day entry to the neighboring Museum of the City of New York; verify that benefit when paying. This could make Friday attractive without paying MCNY's normal adult price.

El Museo del Barrio: admission & hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

16

ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / THREE DOWNTOWN INDOOR CHOICES

Chinatown stories, a restored synagogue & photography

Useful alternatives if the weather turns or if a particular subject catches the group's interest.

$15 EACH · $60 FOR FOUR

Museum of Chinese in America · people and migration

Museum of Chinese in America, 215 Centre Street, New York

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25 & Fri Nov 27 · 11 am–6 pm; closed Tue and Thanksgiving

Explore Chinese American history through personal stories, objects, photographs and changing exhibitions. Allow 60–90 minutes; nearby Chinatown food can be a separate optional tasting stop.

Booking: choose the standard **$15 adult general-admission** ticket on the official page, not the $20 flexible ticket. Confirm any platform fee before paying. The pay-what-you-wish rate is for NYC residents and is not assumed for visitors. A party of four does not meet the museum's eight-person group-reservation threshold.

Museum of Chinese in America: standard tickets ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$15 EACH · $60 FOR FOUR

Museum at Eldridge Street · a dramatic restored interior

Museum at Eldridge Street, 12 Eldridge Street, New York

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24 & Wed Nov 25 · 10 am–5 pm; published closure Nov 26–27

Explore an ornate 1887 synagogue with painted decoration, stained glass and the story of immigrant Jewish New York. The architecture is the experience; allow 45–75 minutes, with self-guided or scheduled docent interpretation.

Advance registration is strongly encouraged. Published adult admission is $15; inspect any online fee before payment. The normal Friday pay-what-you-wish offer is **not a usable promise for this trip**: the visitor page lists both November 26 and 27 as closed for Thanksgiving. That page mixes some other holiday-year details, so reconfirm directly if this stop matters.

Museum at Eldridge Street: tickets & holiday closures ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$18 EACH · $72 FOR FOUR

International Center of Photography · stories in images

International Center of Photography, 79 Essex Street, New York

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24, Wed Nov 25, Fri Nov 27 · regular 10:30 am–6:30 pm

See photography and visual-culture exhibitions at an institution devoted to how images tell stories. This can appeal to travelers interested in cameras, documentary work or strong contemporary visuals. Allow 60–90 minutes.

Tickets: $18 adult admission; reserve a timed entry or buy at the admissions desk. Use on-site pricing to avoid assuming an unverified online fee fits the limit. Closed Thanksgiving, so the usual Thursday-evening $5 offer cannot be relied on during this trip.

International Center of Photography: tickets & hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

17

ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / OPTIONAL SPECIAL-INTEREST STOPS

More history choices under $20

Keep these as independent options, not a reason to cross the city unless the subject genuinely interests the travelers.

$15 EACH · $60 FOR FOUR

Asia Society Museum · Asian art in a smaller setting

Asia Society Museum, 725 Park Avenue, New York

> **Available:** Wed Nov 25: 11 am–2 pm early closure; Fri Nov 27: 11 am–5 pm

Explore a compact Asian-art museum rather than a sprawling collection. Check the current exhibition for the objects and themes on view. Allow 45–75 minutes.

The visitor page explicitly lists **early closure at 2 pm on November 25** and closure on Thanksgiving. Adult admission is $15; use the official page for tickets or visitor-desk instructions. Do not rely on older listings of free Friday evening hours.

Asia Society Museum: admission & holiday hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$10 EACH · $40 FOR FOUR

Fraunces Tavern Museum · Revolutionary New York

Fraunces Tavern Museum, 54 Pearl Street, 2nd floor, New York

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24, Wed Nov 25, Fri Nov 27 · regular noon–5 pm; holiday recheck

An upstairs history museum in the Fraunces Tavern complex, associated with George Washington and Revolutionary-era New York. Explore historic rooms and exhibitions; allow 45–75 minutes. The restaurant downstairs is separate and no meal purchase is required for museum admission.

Buy on arrival: the museum explicitly does not offer advance individual tickets. Adult entry is $10. Confirm holiday hours directly; Thanksgiving is not included as an available museum date in this guide. This is near the downtown harbor rather than the Midtown parade viewing areas.

Fraunces Tavern Museum: on-site admission ↗ | Fraunces Tavern Museum: hours & events ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$7 EACH · $28 FOR FOUR

National Lighthouse Museum · add a stop on Staten Island

National Lighthouse Museum, 200 The Promenade at Lighthouse Point, Staten Island

> **Available:** Fri Nov 27 · 11 am–4 pm; current policy closes Mon–Wed and legal holidays

A small museum about lighthouse technology, navigation and the people who helped ships reach port. It is near St. George ferry terminal, so it offers a reason to explore briefly before taking the free Staten Island Ferry back. Allow 45–60 minutes plus walking.

Admission: $7 for an ordinary adult visit. Use the current visitor page, not an old COVID-era hours page. No advance individual reservation is advertised; organized guided tours have different prices and minimum group sizes. Within this trip, Friday is the usable regular opening.

National Lighthouse Museum: current visitor information ↗ | Map & directions ↗

18

ATTRACTIONS UNDER $20 / OUTDOOR OPTIONS WITH SMALL FEES OR NONE

Gardens, sculpture & room to wander

Late November is about landscape, views and installations—not a promise of summer flowers. Dress for wind and use actual winter closing times.

$10 EACH · $40 FOR FOUR

Wave Hill · gardens overlooking the Hudson

Wave Hill, 4900 Independence Avenue, Bronx

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24, Wed Nov 25, Fri Nov 27 · winter 10 am–4:30 pm

A landscaped estate with Hudson River and Palisades views, garden paths and indoor garden-related spaces when open. Allow 1½–2 hours on site plus travel; this is a quieter, farther-from-Midtown choice.

Walk-in admission: $10 adult; advance ordinary reservations are not required. Winter hours change with daylight saving time, and last entry is 30 minutes before closing. The normal free Thursday offer **does not work on this trip**: Wave Hill explicitly announces closure on November 26, 2026.

Wave Hill: $10 admission & visiting ↗ | Wave Hill: winter-hour rules ↗ | Wave Hill: November 26, 2026 closure ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$6 EACH; FREE WEDNESDAY LATE AFTERNOON

Queens Botanical Garden · a low-key garden walk

Queens Botanical Garden, 43-50 Main Street, Flushing, Queens

> **Available:** Tue/Wed/Fri: 8 am–4:30 pm; Wed free window usable 3–4:30 pm

Explore garden paths and seasonal plantings in Flushing. Allow 45–75 minutes; it is best for someone who enjoys gardens rather than someone seeking a high-energy attraction.

Current rule: adults pay $6 through December 15, or $24 for four. Older claims that the whole November–March season is free are outdated. The weekly free Wednesday window begins at 3 pm, but winter closing is **4:30 pm**, not the generic 6 pm printed for warmer months.

No ordinary advance reservation is advertised; separately priced events are excluded. Closed Thanksgiving. Check for special-event exceptions before using the free window.

Queens Botanical Garden: current seasonal fees & hours ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 · NO TICKET

Socrates Sculpture Park · art on the waterfront

Socrates Sculpture Park, 32-01 Vernon Boulevard, Queens

> **Available:** Nov 24, 25, 27: 9 am–sunset; Thanksgiving: closes 1 pm

An outdoor waterfront park with large-scale contemporary sculpture and installations. Wander, compare favorite pieces and enjoy river views; allow 30–60 minutes. Artwork changes, so check the current exhibition rather than expecting a particular installation.

Free ordinary entry; no reservation. The current holiday policy closes the park at 1 pm on Thanksgiving. It is an optional nearby companion to Noguchi Museum, not a required next stop. Uneven ground, wind and rain can affect comfort.

Socrates Sculpture Park: hours & holiday exceptions ↗ | Socrates Sculpture Park: free access ↗ | Map & directions ↗

19

ATTRACTIONS & FREE BROWSING / GAMES · TOYS · MOVIE-WORLD PHOTOS

Playful indoor stops with no admission purchase

These are shops with visitor experiences, not ticketed attractions. Buying merchandise, personalized items or refreshments is optional; queues and holiday closures still matter.

$0 TO ENTER AND BROWSE

Nintendo New York + FAO Schwarz · Rockefeller Center

Nintendo New York, 10 Rockefeller Plaza, New York

Available: Tue/Wed/Fri regular candidates; Thu Thanksgiving store hours unconfirmed

Nintendo's two-level store has game-related displays, merchandise and demo opportunities when stations are available. FAO Schwarz at 30 Rockefeller Plaza offers theatrical toy displays and its Dance on Piano experience when operating. Allow 30–60 minutes total or visit either store independently.

No ordinary browsing reservation. Demo access and piano participation can involve queues, maintenance or event restrictions and are not guaranteed. Check each store's holiday hours. Custom toys, paid experiences and purchases are not included in the free option.

Nintendo New York: official store ↗ | FAO Schwarz: in-store experiences ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 ORDINARY STORE ENTRY

Harry Potter Shop New York · themed photo opportunities

Harry Potter Shop New York, 935 Broadway, New York

Available: Tue Nov 24, Wed Nov 25, Fri Nov 27 · closed Thanksgiving

Explore themed displays, magical merchandise and built-in photo opportunities, including the Bertie Bott's setting. This is particularly appealing if anyone likes Harry Potter; allow 30–60 minutes plus any entrance queue.

Ordinary store browsing is separate from buying Butterbeer, merchandise or a paid experience. No purchase is needed for the browsing option; special entry rules can apply during busy periods. **The store's official FAQ says it closes on Thanksgiving.** Check the New York page for current hours before going.

Harry Potter Shop New York: photo opportunities ↗ | Harry Potter shops: hours & holiday closures ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$15 SIGHTSEEING ADMISSION · $60 FOR FOUR

Cathedral of St. John the Divine · immense architecture

Cathedral of St. John the Divine, 1047 Amsterdam Avenue, New York

> **Available:** Tue Nov 24, Wed Nov 25, Fri Nov 27 · regular sightseeing 9:30 am–5 pm

Walk through a vast cathedral interior with high vaults, stained glass and chapels. The main appeal is the scale and architecture, not a library visit. Allow 45–75 minutes and respect worshippers.

Use the official sightseeing ticket page: adult entry is $15. Guided specialist tours can cost more and are not included. Thursday's holiday service/sightseeing arrangements are not confirmed here. Worship attendance is not a substitute for a sightseeing ticket.

Cathedral of St. John the Divine: sightseeing tickets ↗ | Map & directions ↗

20

FREE ATTRACTIONS & SEASONAL DISPLAYS / DOWNTOWN LANDMARKS & A FOOD HALL

More free New York places to explore

No assigned day or sequence. These are ordinary public spaces, not a paid tour package.

$0 OUTDOOR MEMORIAL / PUBLIC CONCOURSE

9/11 Memorial pools + the Oculus

9/11 Memorial, 180 Greenwich Street, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 · check current memorial access and special closures

The outdoor memorial's reflecting pools and inscribed names offer a place to remember the lives lost. This is a solemn stop, not entertainment; allow 30–45 minutes and be considerate with photographs. The paid underground museum is separate and is not included.

Nearby, the Oculus transportation hub has a soaring white ribbed interior and public concourses. It can be a short architecture/photo stop. No ordinary outdoor memorial or concourse reservation is required; security and operational restrictions can affect access.

9/11 Memorial: visiting the outdoor memorial ↗ | World Trade Center: Oculus visitor information ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 TO BROWSE · FOOD OPTIONAL

Chelsea Market · a self-directed tasting or browsing stop

Chelsea Market, 75 Ninth Avenue, New York

> **Available:** Tue/Wed/Fri regular candidates; Thu building/vendor hours must be checked

Explore a former industrial building now filled with food counters and shops. Compare displays, choose one optional snack or simply browse. Allow 30–60 minutes; food is individually priced and this is not an included tasting tour.

No general browsing reservation. The building and individual vendors can have different hours, especially Thanksgiving. Check the official visitor page before relying on it as an indoor stop. The High Line is nearby, but there is no requirement to combine them.

Chelsea Market: official visitor information ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$0 TO VIEW PUBLIC DISPLAYS

Hudson Yards holiday lights · a seasonal photo stop

The Shops and Restaurants at Hudson Yards, 20 Hudson Yards, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · posted season Nov 16–Jan 7; verify final holiday hours

The official holiday page describes extensive lights, illuminated figures and a large suspended hot-air-balloon centerpiece in the shopping complex. Allow 30–45 minutes; no observation-deck or Vessel ticket is needed to view ordinary public displays.

The page lists a Monday November 16 lighting event, consistent with the 2026 calendar, but does not print the year beside every detail. **Confirm final seasonal access and Thanksgiving building hours.** It also lists free Santa photos beginning Nov 27, weekdays 5–8 pm on Level 3; queues, capacity and current rules need confirmation before treating that as a guaranteed photo session.

Hudson Yards: holiday lights & Santa updates ↗ | Map & directions ↗

21

EVENTS · CONDITIONAL UNDER-$20 TICKETS / REAL EVENT DATES · LIMITED DISCOUNT INVENTORY

Two November 27 shows with a limited $10 tier

These are genuine dated performances, but not guaranteed under-$20 tickets for four. The normal adult price is $30; include them only if the limited tier is available and the final charge meets your limit.

LIMITED $10 TICKETS; REGULAR ADULT $30

La MaMa: Mirrored Pool · puppetry and live music

La MaMa The Downstairs, 66 East 4th Street, New York

> **Available:** Fri Nov 27 · 7 pm · 2026 performance listed

A collaboration between puppetry and music artists exploring humanity's place in the universe through imagery, movement and sound. It is experimental theater rather than a conventional Broadway musical. Read the show page and content guidance to see whether it appeals.

Book ahead: the official ticket page lists the first ten tickets for each performance at $10, **limit two per person**. Four discounted places were not verified. Two eligible purchasers would each need to follow the limit; do not assume splitting orders creates inventory. Confirm all mandatory fees before purchase.

The $10 member price is a separate benefit, not a discount the party automatically qualifies for. Do not buy a membership simply to make this one show look under $20.

La MaMa: Mirrored Pool ↗ | Mirrored Pool: official November 27 ticket page ↗ | Map & directions ↗

LIMITED $10 TICKETS; REGULAR ADULT $30

La MaMa: Jump Start 2026 · new puppet-theater experiments

The Club at La MaMa, 74 East 4th Street, New York

> **Available:** Fri Nov 27 · 8 pm · 2026 performance listed

A works-in-progress program featuring puppet artists trying out new ideas. Expect a less conventional, small-scale theater experience; the organizer lists a 50–60 minute runtime, with the exact program still subject to details.

Reserve through the official ticket page. The first-ten-at-$10 offer is limited to two per person; normal adult admission is $30. Availability for four and a final all-in discounted checkout were not verified, so this remains a conditional option, not a guaranteed $40 group evening.

La MaMa: Jump Start 2026 ↗ | Jump Start: official November 27 ticket page ↗ | Map & directions ↗

22

WATCHLIST · NOT CONFIRMED ACTIVITIES / SEASONAL OPENING / SELF-SET SPENDING LIMITS

Other fun leads—verify before relying on them

These do not have enough confirmed information to be presented as firm under-$20 activities on the trip dates.

$15 POSTED; NOVEMBER OPENING UNCONFIRMED

Pier 25 miniature golf · if still operating

Pier 25 Mini Golf, Hudson River Park, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 not confirmed · call 347-756-5813 before traveling

An outdoor 18-hole miniature-golf course with water features, bridges and obstacles beside the Hudson. Allow 45–75 minutes. The operator posts $15 for teens/adults and walk-ins only, which would be $60 for four before any additional charges.

Seasonal caution: the generic weather-dependent hours do not establish late-November operation or Thanksgiving opening. Call the operator or use its linked updates. Do not reserve travel time for this without confirmation; it is a lead, not a promised activity.

Pier 25: operator prices & weather updates ↗ | Map & directions ↗

SET A $10–15 CAP; NOT A VERIFIED PACKAGE

Chinatown Fair · an arcade with a spending cap

Chinatown Fair, 8 Mott Street, New York

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · operator advertises 365-day operation; confirm hours

Play rhythm, racing, basketball, air-hockey or other arcade games in a well-known Chinatown game room. Allow 30–60 minutes and decide in advance how much each person will load or spend.

No complete current game/card price list was verified. A $10–15 allowance is a self-imposed cap, not a promised entry or unlimited-play deal. Before loading a card, ask about card charges, minimum reload and the games desired. Use the official contact details to confirm holiday hours.

Chinatown Fair: official location & hours ↗ | Chinatown Fair: games & contact details ↗ | Map & directions ↗

WATCHLIST ONLY · NO INVENTED NOVEMBER LISTINGS

Later-announced concerts, park programs & markets

New York City

> **Available:** Check Nov 24–27 individually as official calendars fill

Lincoln Center, Juilliard and NYC Parks can add free or low-price programs. A broad search did not establish another suitable, bookable under-$20 concert on these exact dates. Thanksgiving recesses and venue closures make generic weekly claims unreliable.

Use the official calendars below and check **date, all-in charge, eligibility, age policy, registration and minimum spend**. Union Square market dates, seasonal model trains and holiday pop-ups should be confirmed on their organizer's site. This watchlist is not counted as confirmed events.

Lincoln Center: official event calendar ↗ | Juilliard: performance calendar ↗ | NYC Parks: free and low-cost events calendar ↗ | Union Square: organizer's holiday market updates ↗ | Map & directions ↗

FOOD / CLASSIC EVERYDAY FOOD

23 Bagels, slices & hot dogs

Walk-in/counter service: no table reservation for these stops. Thanksgiving hours must be checked directly. “Posted” is a published price; “allow” is a planning estimate. Online and counter prices can differ. Group estimates exclude drinks unless stated.

POSTED: $2 CHEESE SLICE

2 Bros Pizza · the smallest meal total

542 Ninth Avenue, near West 40th Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

A quick, simple New York foldable-slice stop, not a long sit-down meal. The location’s merchant menu lists a **$2 plain slice** or **$16 cheese pie**. Eight plain slices for four cost **$16 before tax; about $17.42 with tax**. Two each is a modest meal; add more for larger appetites.

Best near the Port Authority/Midtown West. Allow 15–30 minutes. Order at the counter and choose pickup rather than delivery fees. Prices are for this exact branch, not every 2 Bros.

2 Bros, 542 Ninth Avenue: menu & ordering ↗ | Map & directions ↗

POSTED: $28.47 CHEESE PIE

NY Pizza Suprema · a pizza-focused stop

413 Eighth Avenue, near West 31st Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

A slice shop near Penn Station with classic thin-crust cheese pizza and specialty slices. The merchant’s Slice menu lists an **8-slice cheese pie at $28.47**; that is **about $31 for four with tax**, before drinks or ordering fees. It gives each person two slices.

Try the plain pie first to compare the crust and sauce. Whole-pie pricing can work better for four than choosing many specialty slices. Allow 20–40 minutes; counter price may differ from the online quote.

NY Pizza Suprema: merchant’s Slice menu ↗ | Map & directions ↗

ALLOW $22–35 FOR FOUR

Best Bagel & Coffee · the breakfast classic

225 West 35th Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

Hand-rolled bagels with a wide choice of spreads and fillings. Try an everything or sesame bagel with plain/scallion cream cheese; an egg-and-cheese sandwich is a more substantial option.

Estimate: $5–8 each for a cream-cheese bagel, or roughly $22–35 for four with a tax allowance; coffee and smoked salmon cost extra. The official menu does not publish a complete counter price list. Allow 20–40 minutes including a possible line. Go on a non-parade morning rather than relying on it before dawn.

Best Bagel & Coffee: menu ↗ | Map & directions ↗

POSTED: $30 TOTAL FOR FOUR

Gray’s Papaya · hot dogs & a tropical drink

2090 Broadway at West 72nd Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

An old-school New York hot-dog counter. The official menu lists **two franks plus a medium tropical drink for $7.50 including tax**. Four orders are **$30 total** for eight hot dogs and four drinks; chili/cheese add-ons are extra.

Try mustard, onions or sauerkraut and a papaya drink. This is a quick stand-up/counter stop, not a leisurely restaurant. Allow 15–25 minutes with optional nearby Central Park sightseeing.

Gray’s Papaya: official prices ↗ | Map & directions ↗

24

FOOD / MORE VARIETY, LESS WAITING

Dumplings & New York street-food platters

These are optional alternatives, not three extra meals to fit into one day. Favor the location near your sightseeing, and do not sacrifice an entire afternoon to a famous queue.

ALLOW $31–44 FOR FOUR

Shu Jiao Fu Zhou · a Chinatown tasting stop

295 Grand Street, near Eldridge Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

A casual Fujianese spot known for boiled dumplings and wheat noodles with peanut sauce. Order pork-and-chive or cabbage dumplings and add noodles to share. This gives the group a neighborhood-food experience beyond Midtown pizza.

Planning allowance: $7–10 per person, about $31–44 for four with a tax buffer, for modest dumpling portions/shared noodles. This is **an estimate, not a verified November counter quote**; a third-party reference menu lists 10-piece pork dumplings at $6.75. Check the posted board before ordering and bring some cash as a fallback.

No advance table booking recommended; allow 20–45 minutes and expect simple, limited seating. Peanut noodles are unsuitable for a peanut allergy; ask staff about ingredients. This is an optional detour, not immediately at the bridge entrance.

Shu Jiao Fu Zhou: menu & pickup listing ↗ | Shu Jiao Fu Zhou: reference menu (third-party) ↗ | Map & directions ↗

ALLOW $52–70 FOR FOUR

The Halal Guys · the classic cart experience

West 53rd Street & Sixth Avenue

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

Chicken, beef gyro or falafel over rice with salad and sauces—a filling New York street-food style. The original cart location is convenient to Rockefeller Center. Ask for the hot sauce on the side if unsure how much heat you want.

Estimate: $12–16 per platter; about $52–70 for four with tax allowance. Current exact cart pricing was not verified. Four platters is the safer meal assumption; splitting should be a choice based on appetite, not the reason the meal appears affordable.

No reservation; buy at the cart. Allow 20–40 minutes plus the actual queue. Check its current hours and Thanksgiving operation through the official location page.

The Halal Guys: original cart location ↗ | Map & directions ↗

ALLOW $53–79 FOR FOUR

Adel’s Famous Halal Food · keep as an alternative

1221 Sixth Avenue, near West 49th Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

Chicken or mixed meat over rice, with salad, pita and sauces. It was in the original PDF and remains an option, but it should not dictate the evening. The official menu does not list prices.

Estimate: $12–18 per platter; about $53–79 for four with a tax allowance. It is generally an evening stop; verify the day’s opening time. If the line would absorb a large part of the night, choose another cart or a pizza meal instead. No table reservation; time needed depends heavily on the queue.

Adel’s: official menu ↗ | Map & directions ↗

Make a food trail memorable: give each traveler one pick, share a few tasting portions, and rate the favorites in a phone note. Set a per-stop amount before ordering. Do not assume a small snack portion replaces a full meal for four.

25

FOOD / COOKIES · CHEESECAKE · DELI

The treats you will talk about afterward

Use these as deliberate tasting stops. A takeaway dessert often makes more sense than paying for a full restaurant meal just to try a signature item.

ALLOW $13–16 FOR FOUR TASTINGS

Levain Bakery · split two big cookies

167 West 74th Street, original bakery

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

Thick, substantial cookies with a soft center. Try chocolate-chip walnut or dark-chocolate chocolate-chip. Buy two and divide them into four tasting portions; this is dessert, not lunch.

Estimate: $6–7 per cookie, or $13–16 for two with a tax/price buffer. The official location confirms flavors and pickup links, but not a fixed November counter price. Normal hours currently show 8 am–8 pm; holiday hours may differ. Walk-in/takeaway; no reservation. Allow 15–30 minutes plus any line. Pair with Gray's Papaya.

Levain: original West 74th Street bakery ↗ | Map & directions ↗

POSTED 2026 BAKERY PRICES

Junior's · cheesecake or a black-and-white cookie

1515 Broadway at West 45th Street

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

A classic New York cheesecake name with a takeaway bakery counter near Times Square. The bakery's posted list offers a **Little Fella cheesecake at $5.95** and a **black-and-white cookie at $5.50**.

Four individual Little Fellas are **$23.80 before any applicable tax**; allow about $26. Alternatively, two black-and-white cookies cost **$11 before any applicable tax** and make four shared tasting portions. Food tax treatment can vary by how items are sold, so these allowances are not exact checkout quotes.

No table reservation for the bakery. Allow 15–30 minutes. Choose the bakery/takeout entrance rather than waiting for a sit-down table merely to buy dessert.

Junior's 45th Street: menus & takeout ↗ | Junior's: posted 2026 bakery price list ↗ | Map & directions ↗

NOT AN EVERYDAY LOW-TOTAL MEAL

Katz's Delicatessen · an optional shared splurge

205 East Houston Street, Lower East Side

> **Available:** Nov 24–27 candidates · verify Thanksgiving opening directly

The deli experience is the attraction: hand-carved pastrami on rye, a busy counter and a room full of New York history. Order pastrami with mustard if that appeals, rather than adding multiple sides and drinks.

The official **in-store menu lists pastrami at $30.95**. Two sandwiches to split between four are **$61.90 before tax, about $67.39 with tax**, before tips or extras. Half a sandwich each is a light meal, not a guaranteed full lunch. One sandwich cut into four works only as a tasting stop.

Walk in; allow 45–75 minutes if there is a queue. Keep the ordering ticket you are handed until checkout. Do not cross town for this if it crowds out the activities everyone prefers.

Katz's: in-store menu ↗ | Map & directions ↗

26

THANKSGIVING DINNER / THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 26 · FOUR PEOPLE

Choose the dinner with eyes open

Thanksgiving dinner is a separate food expense, not part of the under-$20 activity collection. Prices below are for four adult meals. Undated menus remain clearly marked for direct confirmation; published offers do not guarantee an available table.

RESTAURANT / CHOICE	PRICE EACH	FOUR, WITH TAX + TIP*	EVIDENCE / STATUS
The Elgin · turkey entrée	$38	≈ $196	Undated; confirm 2026
The Elgin · three courses	$69.95	≈ $361	Undated; confirm 2026
Nice Matin · three courses	$72	≈ $371	2026 menu anchor; confirm
Bond 45 · holiday feast	$79	≈ $407	2026 published
Copinette · three courses	$82	≈ $423	2026 published
Sarabeth's CPS · four courses	$85	≈ $438	2026 published
Tara Mór · three courses + drink	$90	≈ $464	2026 published

What these totals do—and do not—include

***Calculation:** four adult meals + 8.875% restaurant sales tax + a planned 20% tip on the pre-tax food subtotal; rounded to the nearest dollar. These are estimates, not restaurant quotes. Drinks, supplements, platform fees and other charges are extra unless included in the menu. If a service charge/gratuity is included, do not add it twice.

NYC: sales tax ↗

Compare the options without committing yet

The Elgin lists lower-price à la carte turkey choices, but its page does not identify the year. Nice Matin has a current Thanksgiving section; confirm its date and $72 price directly. Neither is presented as a guaranteed holiday offer.

Bond 45, Copinette, Sarabeth's Central Park South and Tara Mór have published Thanksgiving offerings identified for this trip. Use their menu and reservation links to compare atmosphere, inclusions and cancellation terms.

The Elgin also posts a $27 turkey burger with fries, about $139 for four with the modeled tax and tip. It is a different meal from a traditional carved-turkey dinner.

The Elgin: Thanksgiving menu ↗

Nice Matin: current menus & reservations ↗

Bond 45: Thanksgiving 2026 menu & reservations ↗

27

THANKSGIVING DINNER / CONFIRM THE 2026 OFFER BEFORE RELYING ON IT

Lower-price leads to contact first

These current restaurant pages need explicit confirmation for Thursday, November 26, 2026. Ask for four adult meals and the exact menu price, then reserve only if the terms suit the group.

UNDATED MENU: $38 / $69.95

The Elgin · turkey near Rockefeller Center

64 West 48th Street

> **Available:** Thu Nov 26 · reservation and menu confirmation needed

A Midtown bar/restaurant with a $38 carved-turkey entrée, cranberry accompaniment, Brussels sprouts, bacon and gravy; $69.95 adds soup and apple pie. **Four: about $196 or $361**. Ask exactly which sides are included.

Call 212-221-2100 to confirm November 26, 2026, entrée-only ordering, service hours and any age-related dining restrictions. Then reserve through the official OpenTable link. The lower price is useful only if entrée-only ordering is actually offered that day.

The Elgin: Thanksgiving menu ↗ | The Elgin: reservations ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$72 · CONFIRM YEAR DIRECTLY

Nice Matin · a French-bistro alternative

201 West 79th Street

> **Available:** Thu Nov 26 · reservation and menu confirmation needed

Three courses with turkey and several traditional sides, plus other entrée choices and dessert. The current menu page uses a **thanksgiving-2026** section anchor and lists 1–9 pm; the standalone Thanksgiving page does not state the year. **Four: about $371** with modeled tax/tip.

A calmer bistro-style choice for an Upper West Side hotel. **Call 212-873-6423** to explicitly confirm November 26, 2026, the $72 price and the menu, then use its reservation form. This is stronger evidence than a purely old listing, but not the same as an explicitly dated event page.

Nice Matin: current menus & reservations ↗ | Nice Matin: standalone Thanksgiving menu ↗ | Map & directions ↗

28 THANKSGIVING DINNER / MORE CERTAINTY · HIGHER TOTALS

Explicitly published 2026 dinners

Published offers, not verified open tables. Request four adult meals, review deposits/cancellation terms, and confirm any supplements. Exact restaurant timing must still fit hotel access and parade exit.

$79 EACH · ≈ $407 FOR FOUR

Bond 45 · Italian restaurant, traditional feast

221 West 46th Street · 212-869-4545

> **Available:** Thu Nov 26 · reservation and menu confirmation needed

Its Thanksgiving 2026 menu includes a holiday aperitivo, an appetizer choice, herb-roasted turkey with stuffing and vegetables, and dessert. The restaurant also explicitly says its **full à la carte menu is available**, useful if someone does not want the feast.

A lively Theater District setting. Reserve via the official page or call for holiday service hours and the exact dinner time. Ask for a nonalcoholic alternative to the champagne toast for anyone not drinking alcohol. Do not assume an à la carte order costs the same as this fixed-price meal.

Bond 45: Thanksgiving 2026 menu & reservations ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$82 EACH · ≈ $423 FOR FOUR

Copinette · American cooking with French influence

891 First Avenue at 50th Street · 212-903-4001

> **Available:** Thu Nov 26 · reservation and menu confirmation needed

Three-course Thanksgiving dinner in a more polished Midtown East setting. Turkey with seasonal sides is offered alongside alternative mains, and desserts include holiday flavors. The official event page explicitly names **November 26, 2026, noon–9 pm**.

The holiday **prix fixe replaces the regular à la carte menu**. Use “Make Reservation” on the official page or call; reconfirm the posted $82 menu price and any entrée supplement when booking. Do not assume its children’s-price offer applies to this party; four adult meals are costed here.

Copinette: Thanksgiving 2026 & reservations ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$85 EACH · ≈ $438 FOR FOUR

Sarabeth’s Central Park South · four courses

40 Central Park South · 212-826-5959

> **Available:** Thu Nov 26 · reservation and menu confirmation needed

A classic sit-down setting near the park. The 2026 menu includes appetizer, salad, a choice of main and dessert; turkey comes with stuffing, potatoes, vegetables and cranberry compote. **Service November 26, 1–9 pm; holiday prix fixe only.**

Book the **Central Park South** location through SevenRooms, not another branch by accident. Its Thanksgiving page says brunch is closed for a private event. A location on Central Park South is not a promise of parade viewing with dinner; confirm access instructions and cancellation terms.

Sarabeth’s Central Park South: menu & reservations ↗ | Sarabeth’s: Thanksgiving booking page ↗ | Map & directions ↗

$90 EACH · ≈ $464 FOR FOUR

Tara Mór · dinner with an optional music evening

150 West 30th Street · 646-868-7884

> **Available:** Thu Nov 26 · reservation and menu confirmation needed

An Irish pub setting with three courses and a glass of wine or cocktail; turkey with traditional sides is one main. Its 2026 page lists **seatings noon–8 pm** and **live music from 7 pm**. Dishes may also be ordered individually, but those prices are not published.

Book through the page’s Resy button, carefully resetting the date/party size if needed. Before choosing a late music seating, ask any evening age restrictions and nonalcoholic substitutions, whether the drink price changes, and if any music cover/minimum applies. Do not sell this as free entertainment.

Tara Mór: Thanksgiving 2026 & Resy booking ↗ | Map & directions ↗

29

BOOKING CHECKLIST / SAVE THESE DATES

What to arrange—and when

You do not need to book every attraction. Prioritize the hotel's parade arrangements and the one Thanksgiving dinner you actually want.

WHEN	ACTION	WHAT TO VERIFY
Now	Hotel parade viewing	All four included? Exact view/access? Extra fee? Arrival time? Entry during closures?
Now / when dates open	Thanksgiving dinner	Nov 26, 2026; four diners; menu/year/total; deposit; cancellation deadline.
Start checking Oct 23	Whitney for Nov 27, 5–10 pm	Up to five weeks ahead; no verified release hour. Check the departure time before reserving.
Nov 20	Morgan for Nov 27, 5–8 pm	One-week release; exact hour not verified. Reserve if desired; verify the release time.
One week before skating	Bryant Park, own skates	Free own-skate slots roll out daily one week ahead. Rental tickets have separate availability.
Before heading to balloons	Macy's official FAQ	Public viewing, hours, entry point, bag rules and any registration—not yet announced.
7 days before + day before	Holiday hours and transit	Restaurants, museums, carousel, weather/park alerts and NYPD route access.

Booking links

Use official pages below. For each form, select **the exact date, four people and the correct location**; some restaurant buttons currently carry older/default dates. Keep a screenshot of the confirmation and cancellation policy. No bookings have been made as part of this guide.

Reserve Whitney Free Friday tickets ↗

Morgan: Free Friday reservations ↗

Bryant Park: prices, rules & reservations ↗

Macy's: public viewing & balloon updates ↗

One useful restaurant call script

“We are four diners for Thanksgiving on Thursday, November 26, 2026. Is your holiday menu available that day? Can the turkey entrée be ordered by itself? What is the total price, including mandatory charges? Are there supplements, a deposit or a cancellation fee? What times are available, and are there any age restrictions?”

Walk-in choices and ordinary public access

The ferry, bridge, public waterfront, ordinary park walks, tram, Times Square and market browsing do not require an advance sightseeing reservation. Jane’s Carousel sells ordinary rides on site. Weather, queues and operational closures can still affect access. Check NYPL’s own page if choosing its free exhibition rather than assuming every free attraction is ticketless.

NYC DOT: free ferry schedule ↗ | RIOC: Roosevelt Island Tram ↗ | Jane’s Carousel: current hours & tickets ↗ | NYPL: Treasures exhibition & entry ↗

30

BOOKING CHECKLIST / ONLY BOOK WHAT YOU CHOOSE

Reservations for the added options

These are ticket-release or booking dates—not a sightseeing schedule. Some free experiences have limited capacity.

WHEN	OPTION	WHAT TO CHECK
Nov 23 · 3 pm Eastern	Aquarium free entry, Nov 25	Reserve up to four Wednesday tickets; winter last entry 3:30 pm.
Nov 23 · 5 pm Eastern	Bronx Zoo free entry, Nov 25	Select free LIMITED admission, not a paid all-attractions ticket.
Nov 4 / Nov 6	Transit Museum Nov 25 / Nov 27	Tickets roll out three weeks before the visit.
Before Nov 22 cutoff	Seaport Museum, Wed Nov 25	Wednesday preregistration closes three days ahead; select 1–3 or 3–5 pm.
When date appears	Frick Wed / optional paid activities	Check exact-date checkout, fees and any limited price tier.

Other ticket and walk-in rules

Governors Island: reserve the outbound ferry, with return included. Transit Museum and Frick: advance admission is recommended. Zoos require date-specific tickets.

Hex&Co.: $15 walk-in gameplay; advance seating starts at $17 and may have different terms. Cellar Dog: first-come seating; confirm evening age restrictions and any minimum spend.

La MaMa’s limited $10 tickets are not guaranteed for four. Each person may buy no more than two at that tier; follow the venue’s actual policy. No purchase is made by this guide.

Governors Island: official ferry tickets ↗

Transit Museum: Brooklyn tickets, hours & release window ↗

Frick: Wednesday pay-what-you-wish reservations ↗

Hex&Co.: gameplay prices & reservations ↗

Cellar Dog NYC: cover, games & age rules ↗

Jump Start: official November 27 ticket page ↗

PRACTICAL DETAILS / FOR THE WHOLE GROUP

31 Getting around & keeping the daily total down

Walking by neighborhood does more for this trip than buying an attraction pass. Hotel, airfare and airport transfers are not included in the figures below.

Transit: one consistent payment method per person

The current subway/local-bus fare is **$3**. Each traveler should use their own consistent contactless card, device or OMNY card. MTA's individual seven-day subway/local-bus cap is **$35**; do not expect tapping one card four times to give all four people a shared unlimited pass. A physical card and the same card in a phone wallet are not interchangeable for one person's cap.

Example: eight paid rides each cost **$24 per person / $96 for four**; fewer rides cost less. Four individual $35 caps would be $140. These amounts do not include airport rail/AirTrain, express buses or other operators. Check MTA service notices rather than assuming ordinary train patterns on Thanksgiving. Taxis near parade closures are a poor plan.

MTA: current subway & bus fares ↗ | MTA: tap-and-ride & individual fare caps ↗ | MTA: service status & trip planning ↗

Choose extras individually—not a four-day spending package

All admission and ride totals are shown as individual options. Choosing one does not imply doing the others. Meals, airport transfers, shopping and ordinary transport are separate.

For example, four $4 carousel rides cost $16; four $15 admissions cost $60. Four adults can enjoy the free alternatives without buying a pass or taking every paid option.

For paid tickets, review the final checkout amount before confirming. A promotional starting price is not evidence that all four tickets are available at that price.

Small choices with a useful payoff

Carry refillable water, buy takeaway instead of delivery, and compare whole-pie prices before ordering specialty slices. Share desserts intentionally, not every main meal. Buy Wednesday snacks/breakfast provisions before the parade. Leave space for rests when the group wants them. Layer clothing, keep phones charged, and agree on a meeting point if the crowd separates the group.

Keep food choices flexible for allergies and preferences, which have not been provided. Ask restaurants directly about ingredients rather than assuming a dish is safe from its name.

32 REVIEW & FINAL CHECKS / KEEP THE CHOICES FLEXIBLE

Final checks & what is deliberately excluded

This edition retains the free options and adds a broader range of modestly priced experiences. It removes the assigned daily itinerary and obsolete dinner offers.

Avoid misleading bargains

Exactly $20 is outside the requested limit. The Museum of the Moving Image's $20 adult ticket and Japan Society's $20 general ticket are not included as under-$20 choices. Moving Image's regular free Thursday window falls on Thanksgiving; no holiday opening is assumed.

Hidden charges matter: comedy-club drink minimums, skating rentals, processing fees and paid-tour tips can exceed the advertised admission price. Free walking tours with expected tips are not represented as genuinely free guided experiences.

Wrong-date offers: first-Friday and weekend-only discounts are not available simply because the trip includes a Friday. Seasonal boat trips, summer kayaking and a lit Rockefeller tree are not promised for these dates.

What to verify before using a link

Check the exact date, party size, location, price and cancellation terms. Holiday opening can override ordinary weekday hours. Outdoor operations depend on weather; ticket inventory can change.

Verify hotel parade-viewing entitlement in writing. Being on the route does not guarantee a room or lounge view. Add the hotel name and departure times to the traveler's own notes—not to an imposed itinerary.

All free and paid selections link to official information or a venue's booking gateway. No restaurant was called and no reservation was made.

> The HTML and PDF remain readable offline. External maps, menus and reservation pages require internet. The web edition is an options catalog, not a live ticket-availability feed.

See the parade. Walk the skyline. Taste the city.
Prepared for four adults · November 24–27, 2026
Save and share this file. External menus, maps and bookings require internet access.